



HUSTLE STUDIO TOOLKIT

The Case of the Cold Cocoa

A free printable mini mystery for 4-6 players · Clue & Candle Games

Contents

01 Start Here: The Case of the Cold Cocoa

02 Host Scripts and Character Sheets

03 Evidence Cards, Ballot and Solution

Start Here: The Case of the Cold Cocoa

A free mini murder... well, a mini *mystery* for 4 to 6 players. About 45 minutes. Print, cut, play.

From Clue & Candle Games. An original story, written with AI assistance. Free to print for your own home or office party.

The story in one paragraph

It's the Snowbury Winter Fair, and the Great Cocoa Contest is about to be judged. Everyone's favourite is **Alex Bell's** famous velvet cocoa, kept warm in a red tartan thermos. At 2:30 the judge takes one sip and nearly falls off the bench: the cocoa has been **salted**. Somebody wanted Alex to lose, and that somebody is one of your guests.

Nobody gets hurt in this one. It's a gentle warm-up mystery, perfect for trying out a mystery party before you host a bigger one.

What you need

Item	Notes
This PDF	Printed in black and white is fine
Scissors	To cut the evidence cards apart
A pen per player	For the accusation ballot
Hot cocoa (optional)	Unsalted, ideally

Who plays

The **host** plays **Judge Winter** and reads the scripts. The host is not a suspect and knows the solution, so read the Solution page only when you prepare.

Players	Use these suspects
4	Robin Marsh, Sam Ferris, Morgan Pike, Taylor Quinn
5	add Casey Lund
6	add Jo Ashby

Every role works for any gender. Casey and Jo are optional: all evidence still works without them.

How it plays (45 minutes)

1. **Welcome (5 min).** Hand each guest their character sheet. They read it privately.
2. **Introductions (5 min).** Each suspect introduces themselves in character, using the first line on their sheet.
3. **Round 1 (10 min).** The host reads the Round 1 script and lays out evidence cards 1–3. Guests mingle and question each other.
4. **Round 2 (10 min).** Read the Round 2 script, lay out cards 4–6. More questioning. Suspects may reveal their "Round 2" secret.
5. **Round 3 (10 min).** Read the Round 3 script, lay out cards 7–9.
6. **Accusations and reveal (5 min).** Everyone fills in a ballot, then the host reads the Solution aloud.

The one rule for players

You may lie about anything, **except** if you are innocent, you must tell the truth when someone asks you directly where you were between 2:10 and 2:20. The culprit may lie about anything at all.

Host Scripts and Character Sheets

Host: what you need to know

- At **2:00** Alex sipped the cocoa and it was perfect.
- At **2:10** Alex set the thermos on the judging table inside the tent and went out to watch the champion's speech on the stage.
- At **2:20** Judge Winter (you) locked the tent to prepare for judging. Nobody went in after that.
- So the cocoa was salted **between 2:10 and 2:20**. That window is the heart of the mystery.

Opening script (read aloud)

"Welcome, everyone, to the Snowbury Winter Fair! I am Judge Winter. Half an hour ago I took my first sip of Alex Bell's velvet cocoa, the favourite to win this year's contest, and it was salty enough to cure a ham. Someone sabotaged it. The tent was only open for ten minutes, from ten past two to twenty past two. Every one of you was at the fair. Nobody leaves until we know who did it."

Round 1 script

"Let's start with what we know. Here is my tasting note, a photograph taken at two o'clock, and the salt from the catering table. Talk to each other. Who was near the tent?"

Lay out **evidence cards 1, 2 and 3**.

Round 2 script

"Our photographer has handed over more pictures, and the face-painting stall has sent its sign-in sheet. Some of you have been less than honest about your afternoon."

Lay out **evidence cards 4, 5 and 6**. Remind players they may now reveal their Round 2 secret.

Round 3 script

"One last search. I found something on the thermos lid, something in the VIP welcome bags, and a letter that someone tried to tear up. Ten minutes, then I want your accusations."

Lay out **evidence cards 7, 8 and 9**.

Robin Marsh: the Reigning Champion

Introduce yourself: "Robin Marsh, three-time cocoa champion. Alex's cocoa? Pleasant. A little sweet."

Your afternoon: At 2:08 you walked onto the stage to give the champion's speech. You spoke until 2:20 with the brass band behind you. Half the fair saw you.

Your secret (Round 1): You were desperate to win a fourth title, and you told Sam this morning, "I'd do anything to beat Alex this year." You regret saying it.

Round 2: Admit you received a VIP welcome bag as reigning champion. It contained a sachet of pink sea salt. If anyone asks, show that your sachet is still sealed (see evidence card 8).

You are innocent.

Sam Ferris: the Caterer

Introduce yourself: "Sam Ferris, I run the hot chestnut cart and the sugar-and-salt table. If it's warm and tasty, I made it."

Your afternoon: From 2:10 to 2:20 you were serving roast chestnuts at your cart across the green, with a queue the whole time. Your till printed receipts.

Your secret (Round 1): Alex refused to let you sell Alex's cocoa at your cart this year, and you were annoyed. Also, the salt on the condiment table is yours.

Round 2: Point out that your table only has fine white table salt. You've never stocked pink salt.

You are innocent.

Morgan Pike: Alex's Cousin

Introduce yourself: "Morgan Pike. Alex's cousin and, for the record, co-inventor of that cocoa recipe."

Your afternoon: At 2:10 you went to the face-painting stall and had a snowflake painted on your cheek. You were there until 2:22.

Your secret (Round 1): You think half the recipe is yours and Alex never gives you credit. You had a loud argument with Alex at lunchtime. Try to keep this quiet at first.

Round 2: You may say where you were. The face-painting sign-in sheet proves it (evidence card 5).

You are innocent.

Taylor Quinn: the Fair Organiser

Introduce yourself: "Taylor Quinn, fair organiser. Every rosette, every bunting flag, every welcome bag: me."

Your afternoon (the truth): You left the gate at 2:05, saying you needed more rosettes. You slipped into the empty tent at 2:12 and tipped a sachet of pink sea salt into Alex's thermos, then went back to the gate at 2:25.

Why: The sponsor, Fizzwell Foods, promised to pay for a new village hall roof if its own cocoa won. Alex's cocoa was going to win. You did it for the roof.

What to say: Claim you were at the gate taking tickets all afternoon. Try to steer suspicion to Robin (who wanted to win) and Morgan (who argued with Alex).

You are the culprit. You may lie about anything. Don't confess unless someone shows you cards 6, 7 and 9 together.

Casey Lund: the Photographer (optional, 5+ players)

Introduce yourself: "Casey Lund, official fair photographer. If it happened, I've got a picture."

Your afternoon: At 2:00 you photographed Alex tasting the cocoa. From 2:08 to 2:20 you were in the front row photographing Robin's speech. Every photo has a timestamp.

Your secret (Round 1): Alex refused to buy your photos last year and you've grumbled about it ever since.

Round 2: Offer your photos as proof of where Robin, Jo and you were (evidence card 4).

You are innocent.

Jo Ashby: the Bandleader (optional, 6 players)

Introduce yourself: "Jo Ashby, leader of the Snowbury Brass Band. Loudest trombone in the county."

Your afternoon: You played behind Robin on stage from 2:08 to 2:20.

Your secret (Round 1): Your band was supposed to get the sponsor's money this year, until Taylor said it was going to "something more important". You're curious what.

Round 2: Mention that Taylor was not at the gate when the band walked past at 2:07. The gate volunteer was alone.

You are innocent.

Evidence Cards, Ballot and Solution

Cut along the table lines. Lay the cards out face up in the round shown.

Round 1

Card 1: Judge's tasting note

"2:30. Alex Bell's entry: shockingly salty. Coarse **pink** crystals at the bottom of the cup. Tent was locked by me at 2:20."

Card 2: Photo, timestamp 2:00

Alex sips from the red tartan thermos and gives a thumbs up. Caption: "Perfect as ever." At 2:10 Alex carried the thermos into the tent and came straight back out.

Card 3: The condiment table

A shaker of **fine white table salt** from Sam's catering supplies. Sam's stock list: "table salt x 4, sugar x 10." No other salt listed.

Round 2

Card 4: Photo series, 2:08 to 2:20

Twelve timestamped photos from the front row: Robin speaking on stage, the brass band (with Jo) playing behind. Taken by Casey.

Card 5: Face-painting sign-in sheet

"Morgan Pike: snowflake, left cheek. In 2:10, out 2:22."

Card 6: Gate volunteer's note

"Taylor left the gate at 2:05 to fetch more rosettes. Back at 2:25 without any rosettes."

Round 3

Card 7: The thermos lid

Specks of **gold glitter** on the lid. The only gold glitter at the fair is on the prize rosettes, which Taylor has been pinning on all day.

Card 8: The VIP welcome bags

Each bag holds a sachet of **pink sea salt**. Taylor packed them. Robin's bag: sachet still sealed. Taylor's spare box: one sachet missing.

Card 9: A torn letter

From Fizzwell Foods to Taylor Quinn: "...if the Fizzwell entry takes first prize, we will gladly fund the new village hall roof..."

Accusation ballot (cut one per player)

Ballot

Your name: _____ I accuse: _____ Because (one clue): _____

Ballot

Your name: _____ I accuse: _____ Because (one clue): _____

Ballot

Your name: _____ I accuse: _____ Because (one clue): _____

Solution (host reads aloud)

"The cocoa was perfect at two o'clock (card 2), and I locked the tent at twenty past (card 1). So the salt went in between ten past and twenty past two.

The salt was coarse and pink (card 1), so it did not come from Sam's table, which only had white table salt (card 3). Sam was at the chestnut cart anyway.

Robin was on stage the whole ten minutes, with Jo's band behind, in twelve timestamped photos taken by Casey (card 4). Robin's pink salt sachet is still sealed (card 8). Morgan was having a snowflake painted until 2:22 (card 5).

That leaves one person nobody can place: **Taylor Quinn**, who left the gate at 2:05 and came back at 2:25 without the rosettes they went to fetch (card 6). Taylor packed the pink salt and is one sachet short (card 8). Taylor's gold rosette glitter is on the thermos lid (card 7). And Fizzwell Foods promised Taylor a new roof if its cocoa won (card 9).

Taylor Quinn salted the cocoa, for the sake of the village hall roof!"

Players who named Taylor win the Golden Mug (a mug of cocoa, unsalted).

Clue chain check (for the host)

- Window: cards 1 + 2 → 2:10–2:20.
- Salt type: cards 1 + 3 → not Sam's salt.
- Alibis: card 4 → Robin, Jo, Casey. Card 5 → Morgan. Sam: the salt type (card 3) rules out Sam's supplies, and Sam's queue at the cart is the alibi.
- Culprit: card 6 (opportunity) + cards 7 and 8 (means) + card 9 (motive) → Taylor.

Enjoyed the mini mystery?

Try our full Christmas game, **A Very Merry Murder**: 6–12 players (up to 16), 12 character booklets, 12 evidence cards over 3 rounds, a zero-experience host guide with read-aloud scripts, and an editable party planner. A 2.5-hour party, ready to print. **\$17 at phien0618.github.io**